

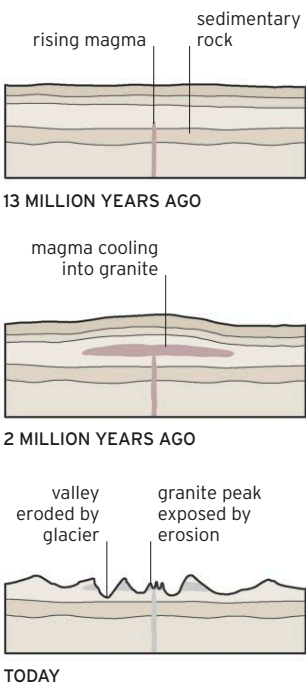
The Torres del Paine

An area of astonishing scenic beauty in Patagonia with snow-capped mountains, glaciers, waterfalls, lakes, and rivers



HOW THE TOWERS FORMED

The Torres del Paine was formed partly from granite that originated from magma rising into the subsurface 13 million years ago. The magma cooled to form a granite block, which was later exposed when the area was eroded by glaciers.



Some 1,220 miles (1,960 km) south of Santiago, the capital of Chile, lies one of South America's most spectacular national parks, the Torres del Paine (Towers of Paine). *Paine*, pronounced "pie-nay," means "blue" in the native Tehuelche language—a reference to the fact that the park's mountains appear slightly azure from a distance.

Granite spires and sharp peaks

One of the most iconic features of the Torres del Paine is a group of three huge granite spires—the torres, or towers—rising 4,900 ft (1,500 m) above the Patagonian steppe. Close by, and part of the same massif, are the Cuernos del Paine (Horns of Paine)—three



enormous mountains surmounted at their tops by sharp black "tusks" of rock. For many visitors, these are the outstanding attraction because of their spectacular forms, sharp edges, and different rock colors. Other high peaks in the park include Cerro Paine Grande at 9,460 ft (2,884 m) and Mount Almirante Nieto at 8,660 ft (2,640 m).

One of the world's last remaining wildernesses, the Torres del Paine has a unique range of wildlife, including guanacos, foxes, rheas, and Andean condors. The park is adorned with beautiful vegetation, including evergreen shrubs, such as Chilean Fire Bush.

THE THREE TOWERS

Torre Sur on the left, Torre Centrale, rising to 9,200 ft (2,800 m), and Torre Norte on the right form the three-tower granite centerpiece of the park.

TOWERING HIGH

The black-topped Cuernos del Paine, which soar to more than 8,200 ft (2,500 m), are visible on the left here, while Mount Almirante Nieto can be seen on the right.

